

Positions, please!

Pabst says someone changing position in the crowd is the first clue that they are going to soon bid. They will move forward from the back of the audience and put themselves in the auctioneer's eyeline. If you intend to bid, stand near the front and eyeball the auctioneer.

Hold the power

If the property is passed in, make sure it is to you. Don't wait to find out if the price isn't met and attempt to low-ball your way in; if you want the property, for goodness' sake, bid. 'The amount of times that the person who is the highest bidder goes in to negotiate; eight or nine times out of ten the agent comes out with a sold sticker and puts that up on the board.' A lot of buyers hold back and hope, but it's an error, Pabst says.

Maintain respectful relationships

Don't be a smart alec to the agent, before or during the auction, Pabst says. 'They are not going to give you any grace if you treat them like a fool. They have a job to do; don't be obnoxious.'

Also, don't ask whether the property is on the market during the auction, Pabst advises. The auctioneer will tell the crowd when it is. He says:

You will also know from the body language of the auctioneer. If [they are] slowing down the pace, speaking slowly and trying to drag out bids, or ... go inside to speak to the vendor, you know [the price is] yet to hit reserve. But if the auction is fast and [the auctioneer is] rapidly taking bids, you know it's at reserve and going to get knocked down.

Asking the auctioneer if the reserve has been hit sends a message to them to look to stronger bidders, who might have also noticed your wobble.